America
(It's Gotta Be the Cheese)
By Jim Daniels and Eitan Kadosh

Short-Order Cook by Jim Daniels

(Pg 9) An average joe comes in
and orders thirty cheeseburgers and thirty fries.

I wait for him to pay before I start cooking.
He pays.
He ain't no average joe.

The grill is just big enough for ten rows of three.
I slap the burgers down
throw two buckets of fries in the deep frier
and they pop pop, spit spit. . .
pssss. . .
The counter girls laugh.
I concentrate.
It is the crucial point--
they are ready for the cheese:

4NG Fanatics

my fingers shake as I tear off slices
toss them on the burgers/fries done/dump/
refill buckets/burgers ready/flip into buns/
beat that melting cheese/wrap burgers in plastic/
into paper bags/fries done/dump/fill thirty bags/
bring them to the counter/wipe sweat on sleeve
and smile at the counter girls.
I puff my chest out and bellow:
Thirty cheeseburgers! Thirty fries!
I grab a handful of ice, toss it in my mouth
do a little dance and walk back to the grill.
Pressure, responsibility, success.
Thirty cheeseburgers, thirty fries.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jim Daniels
Book: Show and Tell: New and Selected Poems by Jim Daniels, Pg 9
ISBN: 978-0299185848
Publisher: University of Wisconsin Press
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

INTRODUCTION

Fast, greasy American diners! They even make TV series about them. They are part of what makes America, well . . . America! But have you ever asked people from other countries what they think about Americans? Our school had the opportunity to host some foreign exchange students this year, and I was amazed to find out just how different they found Americans to be:

1. *We talk to strangers randomly in public places.*
2. *Teenagers get jobs, drive cars and are encouraged to move out of the house at 18. (in other countries children live with their parents until they get married)*
3. *In American everything is Super-Sized, Jumbo, XXL (not true in most countries)*
4. *And our eating habits are weird – we eat whenever and wherever . . . all the time!*

Well, Americans may seem odd to people from other countries, but I know what's really special about the USA and so does Eitan Kadosh.

America (It's Gotta Be the Cheese) by Eitan Kadosh

America (It's Gotta Be the Cheese) by Eitan Kadosh

(Pg 58-59) Everybody writes about America

And everybody paints America

Because from Jasper Johns to Allen Ginsberg

4NG Fanatics

They are all looking for the same thing

Searching for the real America

The one that lies under the costumes and the war paint

that lies under the Seinfeld and Springer

under the bad *movies* and good basketball

And I am no exception

Except that one night, late last week

I actually found it, this elusive America -- in the dairy case at

Andronico's market

Lurking beside the jacks and the cheddars, the goudas,

swisses, stiltons, jarlsbergs, gorgonzolas, whole parmesan,

ricottas, and myriad other imported and domestic cheeses

There -- it beckoned suddenly

An immaculately wrapped unbelievably orange package of

American Pasteurized Process Cheese food glory

God bless this country

We pasteurized

We processed

We manipulated this cheese until it suited our purposes

This was engineered cheese

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

This was the scientific method at work -- Jonas Salk Albert Einstein Copernicus
This was smooth no lumps melted technology at work --
the light bulb phonograph model T radio television internet
Nike Air rolled into one
And all for $1.99

I was so moved I broke into the Pledge of Allegiance right there and then
I bought Charlton Heston's autobiography
Became a Daughter of the American Revolution
Oh god how I long to be wrapped in golden singles of American cheese.
Drizzled with its salty goodness
Oh god put me in a sauna so that the cheese will melt and
when it does it will melt evenly over every square inch of my body.
Rivulets of warm cheese will run down my face like tropical rain caress my body
Oh god
Take me

4NG Fanatics

Take me and dip me like fondue into your vat of silken American cheese food products scoop it on to me like a nacho and let it cool like a second skin oh god cheese food I will use it for everything

For breakfast melted on an English muffin for lunch in a sandwich with processed lunch meat processed salad spread on processed white bread for dinner obliterating my broccoli at bed on my toothbrush so my breath will be cheesy American fresh in the morning I will gargle with it and wash my face with a congealed vat of the stuff I keep on my sink and smear on like Noxema.
I will cook my girlfriend romantic dinners in which every course will concisely and creatively utilize and emphasize our most holy of sacraments.
Because it's gotta be the cheese.

America land of the free – it's gotta be the cheese
Home of the brave – it's gotta be the cheese
Land of possibility, opportunity and the certain unalienable rights of

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

manifest destiny – it's gotta be the cheese

who shot J.F.K, J.R. Ewing, J.C. Penney – it's gotta be the cheese

the WWF – it's gotta be the cheese

Kurt Cobain – it's gotta be the cheese

Jerry Lewis – it's gotta be the cheese

The hydrogen bomb the neutron bomb and pantyhose

Mom the flag and apple pie

It's gotta be the cheese

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Eitan Kadosh
Book: Poetry Slam: The Competitive Art of Performance Poetry, Pgs 58-59
ISBN: 978-0916397661
Publisher: Manic D Press
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

4NG Fanatics

Source information for Introduction
https://blog.icesusa.org/americans-do-the-strangest-things

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY